

FASHION

DELHI

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A tryst with a dress

In the burgeoning fashion industry, the designer's publicity spiel is as perfect as his cuts, and the hunger for fame as intense as the desperation to dress the multitudes

■ By Purvi Malhotra

Grecian style mini-altars and pillars line the stage, while music echoing the '80s disco beat, accompanied by strobe lighting, dazzles the crowd sitting in the hall. Back stage, everyone stares at the over-and-under-dressed audience, as 22-year-old designer Prashant Verma makes his debut at the Wills India Fashion Week, 2007. A model clad in the label Prashant* begins her seductive catwalk, screaming elegance, exemplifying what the label stands for—a gut-felt visceral and sexual human ambition, says the young designer from Delhi. Onlookers analyse how another fledgling in the ocean of designers takes his first flight in a show which lasts for precisely 13 minutes. These 780 seconds will either make him stand out or camouflage him among the rest.

Attitude wins over ability when it comes to designers of the 21st century. Cooped up in a cocoon-like-studio at his Delhi home, filled with fabric, nine tailors, mannequins and concepts decorating the walls, Verma's ideas kindle to life amid a melody of chaos. Just

five years ago, leaving behind the family-run business in electronics, 18-year-old Verma fled to UK to give his ambition a face. Now making his debut as a solo designer in mainstream fashion, after working with Manish Arora, Rohit Gandhi and Rahul Khanna, Verma presents a story of aspiration through his collection. Deserting the Lindsay Lohans and the Paris Hiltons of the world, this new kid on the block looks towards old glamour girls like Marilyn Monroe. An escape from the frenzy of glittering tube tops and low-waisted jeans, he believes in catering to the prim and the genteel, with classic evening wear gowns and modishly cut short dresses accessorised with Swarovski. Verma trained with Alexander McQueen in London and graduated from NIET in 2005. Fashion, to him is an essence of the self—single, unending and fierce. The spin is almost as fine as his cuts. This stilted industry isn't standing on the sole calibre of designers. It is the hundreds of sub-industries like public relations firms that thrive within this mother ship, providing a ticket to instant fame. Newcomers like Verma are



12

MILLION IS THE ESTIMATED NUMBER OF JOBS TO BE GENERATED IN THE TEXTILE INDUSTRY BY 2010